



Coordinator Guide

Knox Church Waitara

May 2026

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Quick Start Guide — Orchestrating with Empathy

Rostas a Better way to Roster Volunteers

Orchestrating with Empathy: The Rostas Quick Start Guide

A complete system for building rosters, managing replacements, and protecting your volunteers' energy.



NotebookLM

Scheduling that Respects Real Life

Rostas acts as an empathy engine. It acknowledges that availability fluctuates, energy levels differ, people get sick, and everyone needs a break.



No Login Friction

Personalized, secure links sent straight to inboxes.



Energy Protection

Built-in frequency caps limit how often a volunteer is scheduled.



Stress-Free Opt-Outs

One-tap 'Can't make it' buttons for when life happens.



Respectful Boundaries

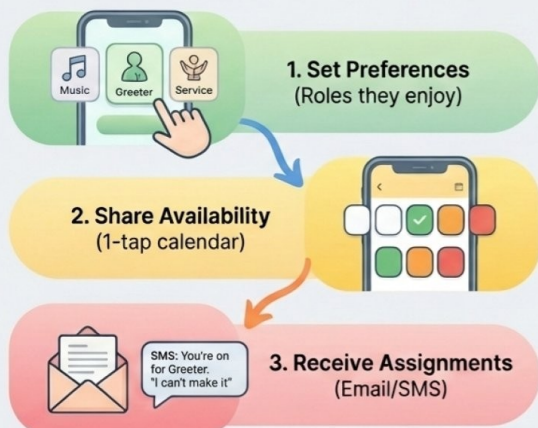
Quiet Hours automatically pause SMS notifications between 9:00 PM and 7:00 AM.

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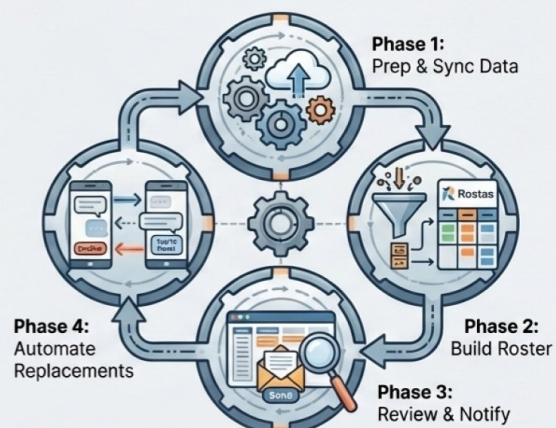
Two Perspectives, One Seamless System

Rostas handles complex logic behind the scenes so the volunteer experience remains distilled to just three low-friction steps.

The Volunteer Journey



The Coordinator Engine



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Coordinator Capabilities at a Glance

System access is purposefully distilled to protect data integrity. Infoodle acts as the ultimate source of truth for membership.

	Roster Coordinator	Overall Coordinator	Tech Support
Sync volunteers from Infoodle	✓	✓	✓
Sync roster types	✓	✓	✓
View/Edit volunteer data	✓	✓	✓
Build/Edit rosters	✓	✓	✓
Manage Replacements	✓	✓	✓
Sync volunteers from Infoodle		✓	✓
Add new volunteers/roster		✓	✓
Add new volunteers/roster types		✓	✓
Apps Script / Technical changes			✓

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Step 0 & 1: Laying the Groundwork

Before asking volunteers for availability, the system requires a synchronized foundation. Never build on outdated data.

Step 0: Refresh Calendar

0. Refresh calendar

Function: Recalculates season dates and overlays NZ public and school holidays.



Rule: Always run after editing season dates or starting a new cycle.

Step 1: Sync Volunteers

1. Sync volunteers from Infoodle

Function: Pulls fresh volunteer data and group memberships from Infoodle (runs automatically at 2 AM, or manually). **Note:** Overall Coordinator task.



Warning: Infoodle is the source of truth. Name changes or new volunteers must be added there first, then synced.

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Step 2 & 3b: Setting Preferences and Protecting Energy

Rostas needs to know what people are willing to do, and how often they can safely do it without burning out.

Step 2: Role Preferences

✓ Guitar Acoustic Yes, I do this	□ Happy to fill in Happy to fill in
✗ Sound Tech Not for me	✗ Electric Not for me
✗ Electric Not for me	✗ Drums Not for me
✗ Keys Not for me	✓ Worship Leader Yes, I do this
✓ Vocals Yes, I do this	✗ Bass Not for me

Sent via personalized link, or set manually by Coordinator.

Step 3b: Frequency Caps

Max Days Rostered

4 Days Per Month

Sets a monthly maximum per roster type (Defaults to 4 for weekly, 2 for fortnightly)

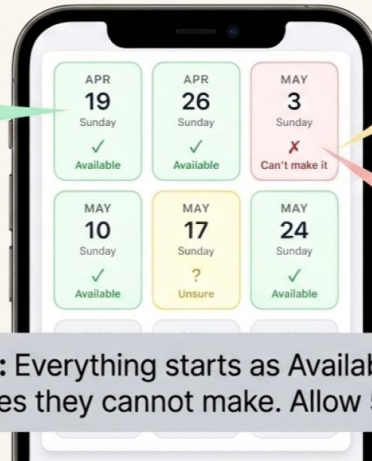
Insight: The engine strictly enforces this. Once a cap is reached, the system will not assign them, even if they marked themselves 'Available'.

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Step 3: Gathering Availability Without Friction

Sent 2–3 weeks before a season begins. Volunteers receive a secure link requiring no passwords. They simply tap dates to cycle through their status.

Available: The default starting state for all dates.



Unsure: Signals caution to the coordinator.

Can't make it: Immediately removes them from the scheduling pool for that date.

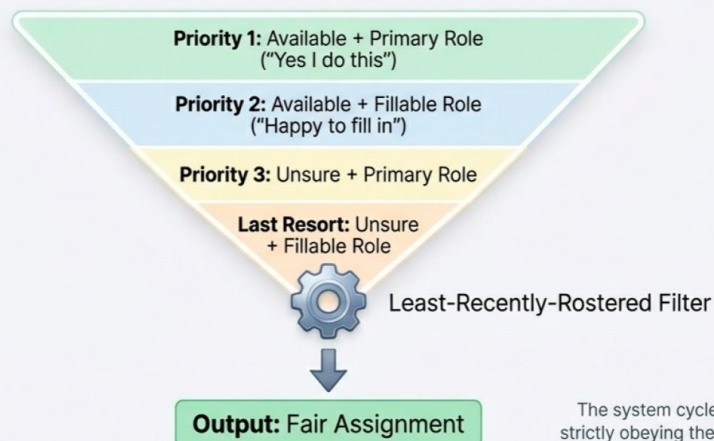


Clever User Interface: Everything starts as Available — volunteers only spend time changing the dates they cannot make. Allow 5-7 days for responses.

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Step 4: The Roster Engine Logic

The automated engine (building 8 weeks by default) doesn't fill slots blindly. It uses a strict priority matrix to make intelligent, fair assignments.



The system cycles through this logic while strictly obeying the monthly frequency caps.

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Never dispatch notifications blindly. Review the Global Roster Day View first to address gaps and ensure accuracy.

Filled
Volunteer is confirmed and ready.

Pending
Volunteer marked 'Unsure' but is provisionally assigned. Requires monitoring.

Unfilled
No suitable volunteer found. Requires manual intervention before sending.

Warning: Do not run Step 5 (Send Notifications) until all Red 'Unfilled' slots are managed or acknowledged.

Verify the formatting, then release the schedule. Every assignment email doubles as a safety net if circumstances change.

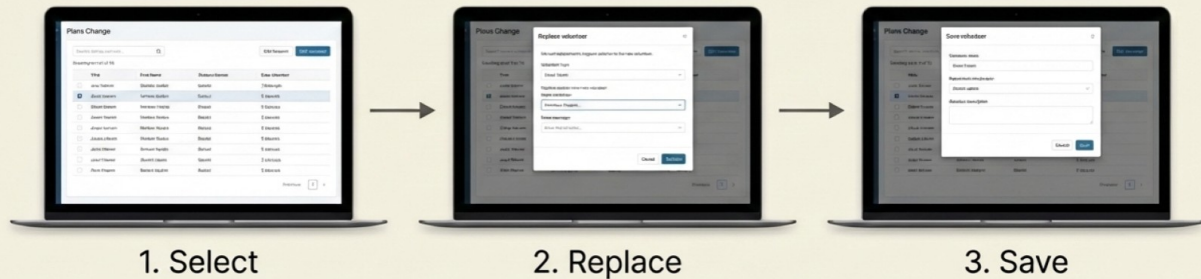
Only required to confirm or reject the Yellow uncertain roster assignments.

Clear date, role, and printable roster links.

Empowering the volunteer: Sickness happens. This button instantly triggers the automated rescue chain.

When Plans Change: Manual Interventions

Manual replacements are required when plans change unexpectedly. After selecting the new volunteer to fill the gap, ensure you save the changes to update the roster

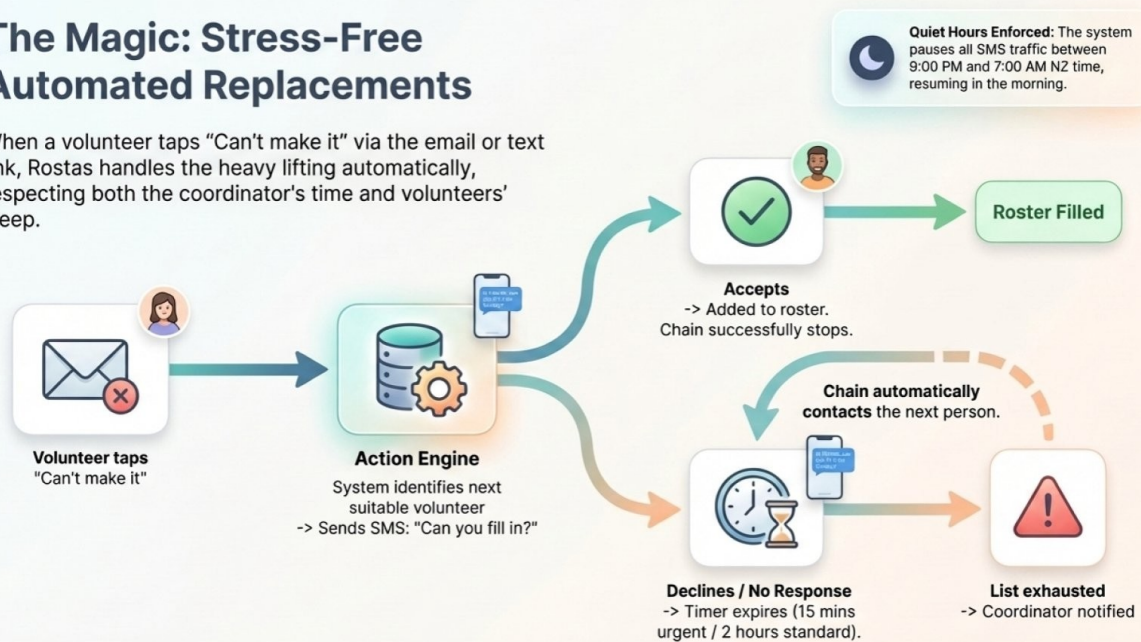


Manual replacements trigger an automated notification to the new volunteer

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The Magic: Stress-Free Automated Replacements

When a volunteer taps "Can't make it" via the email or text link, Rostas handles the heavy lifting automatically, respecting both the coordinator's time and volunteers' sleep.



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Status Dashboard: Checking Notifications

You can check the status of notifications sent from Rostas in the Status Dashboard. If an error occurs you can click the email tech support button to get problems sorted.

Status Dashboard			
Notification Type	Recipient	Status	Time Sent
SMS Request	Sarah T.	Delivered	10:00 AM
SMS Reminder	John B.	Failed	10:05 AM
Email Notification	Emily R.	Sent	10:15 AM
Email Notification	Emily R.	Sent	10:15 AM
SMS Reminder	Sarah T.	Delivered	10:15 AM

 **Email Tech Support**

Click to report errors

Best Practice: you can check that Rostas is doing what it's meant to do in the Status Dashboard after running commands. If there is an error and the message doesn't help you fix it you can contact the tech support person. The email link automatically includes any error log.

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Under the Hood: Managing Settings

Global settings dictate system behavior. Know what you can safely adjust and what requires technical support.



Safe to Adjust

- Coordinator names & emails
- Reminder timing (minutes between texts)
- Email and SMS message wording templates



Leave to Tech Owner

SMS_ENABLED (Controls live delivery)
WEBAPP_URL (Breaks volunteer links)
INFOODLE_GROUP_MAP (Breaks database sync)
ROSTER_FREEZE_WEEKS (Protects past dates)



Support Card

Contact Guy for anything in the red column or for adding entirely new roster types.

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Summary: Best Practices for Empathetic Rostering

Master the system by following these four foundational rules to empower your volunteers and simplify your scheduling.



Database Sync

1. Sync First

Always pull fresh Infoodle data and run Step 0 on season changes before building.



Calendar Clock

2. Give Notice

Send availability requests 2-3 weeks early to respect people's planning time.



Traffic Light

3. Review Before Sending

Never dispatch notifications blindly. Check for 'Red' unfilled slots first.



Interconnected Nodes

4. Trust the Chain

Let the automated SMS system handle sick calls and replacements.

Empower your volunteers. Simplify your scheduling.

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A complete guide to building rosters, managing replacements, and protecting your volunteers' energy.

Knox Church Waitara

Introduction

Rostas is the coordinator app for managing Church & Community volunteer rosters. It currently connects to the Infoodle database to access volunteer data, and handles notifications, reminders, and SMS replacements automatically using Twilio or Clicksend SMS services. Both these services are paid services requiring a subscription.

This guide covers everything you need: from collecting availability through to handling replacements. **Part A** introduces Rostas with a video and overview. **Part B** covers Roster Coordinator tasks. **Part C** covers additional Overall Coordinator tasks for those who have database access. **Part D** covers expert/technical tasks requiring Apps Script access.

Who Can Do What

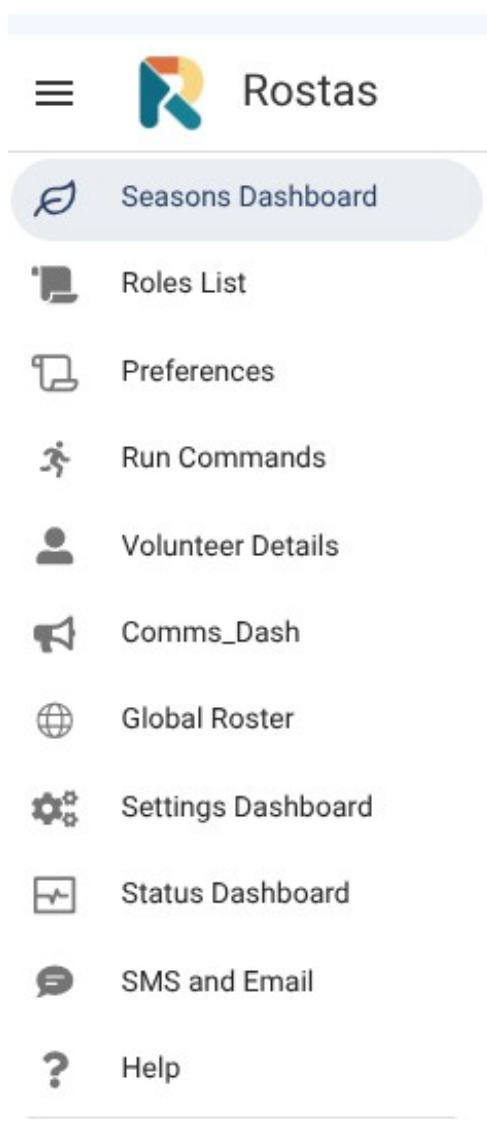
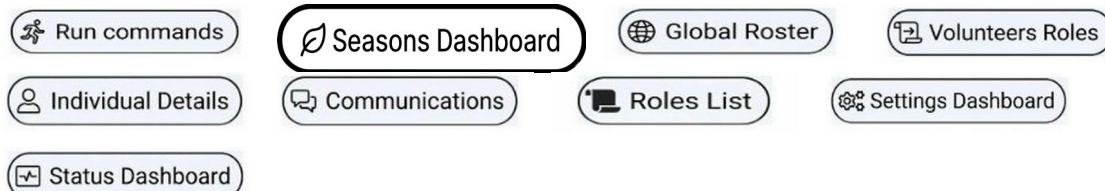
Part B covers all tasks marked ✓ for Roster Coordinators. Part C covers the additional tasks available to Overall Coordinators only.

1. Getting Started with Rostas

Rostas is built primarily for desktop access, though it can also be used on a tablet.

The Rostas Views

When you open Rostas you will see these views in the left-hand sidebar. Tap the relevant view to navigate to that area of the system.



The Rostas left-hand sidebar — tap any view to navigate to that area.

The Run Commands view is your main working area. This is where you trigger all roster actions — sending emails, building the roster, and sending

notifications. Each button runs a single action and shows you the result when it is done. After tapping a button, Rostas queues the action and runs it within about 1 minute. A *Complete* message appears in the Status column when done — always check this before moving on.

The screenshot shows the Rostas application interface. The top bar includes the Rostas logo, a search bar for 'Run commands', and a user profile icon. The main content area is divided into three panels:

- Roster commands:** Contains three sections:
 - 0. REFRESH CALENDAR:** Includes 'Refresh Seasons Calendar' (Re-calculate all roster dates, holidays, and exclusions).
 - 1. SYNC VOLUNTEERS:** Includes 'Sync volunteers from Infoodle' (Pull latest member data from Infoodle).
 - 2. SEND ROLE PREFERENCE EMAILS:** Includes 'Send Music role preference emails', 'Send Nourish role preference emails', and 'Send Sunday role preference emails'.
 - 3. SEND AVAILABILITY EMAILS:**
- Command history:** A table showing the results of executed commands.

Command	Parameters	Status	Requested_By	Request Date
refreshactions		Complete	newsletters@waita...	11/4/26
refreshactions		Complete	newsletters@waita...	10/4/26
refreshactions		Complete	newsletters@waita...	10/4/26
refreshactions		Complete	newsletters@waita...	10/4/26
refreshactions		Complete	newsletters@waita...	10/4/26
refreshSeasonsC...		Complete	newsletters@waita...	10/4/26
refreshactions		Complete	newsletters@waita...	10/4/26
- Date Roster:** A calendar view for April 2026 showing volunteer assignments for each day. The calendar is color-coded by role: Music (green), Nourish (blue), and Sunday (red). The current date is April 11th.

Run Commands — your main working area. Each button triggers one roster action. The Command history panel shows results.

Reading Results

Every action writes a result message in the Command history panel. Common results:

- **Filled: 12, Pending: 3, Unfilled: 0** — roster built successfully. Pending means a volunteer marked Unsure but has been provisionally assigned.
- **Unfilled: 2** — two slots could not be filled. Review the roster and handle manually.
- **Sent to: 14 volunteers** — notification emails dispatched.
- **Error: ...** — something went wrong. Note the message and contact tech support if it repeats.

The Roster Cycle

Each roster follows the same sequence of steps. Run them in order — skipping a step or running them out of order can produce unexpected results.

Timing tip: Send availability emails at least 2-3 weeks before the first date of the new season. Allow volunteers 5-7 days to respond before building the roster.

Normal roster workflow: Step 0 (Refresh calendar) → Step 1 (Sync Volunteers) → Step 2 (Set New Role Preferences) → Step 3 (Availability emails) → Step 4 (Build roster) → Step 5 (Preview — check before sending) → Step 6 (Send notifications).

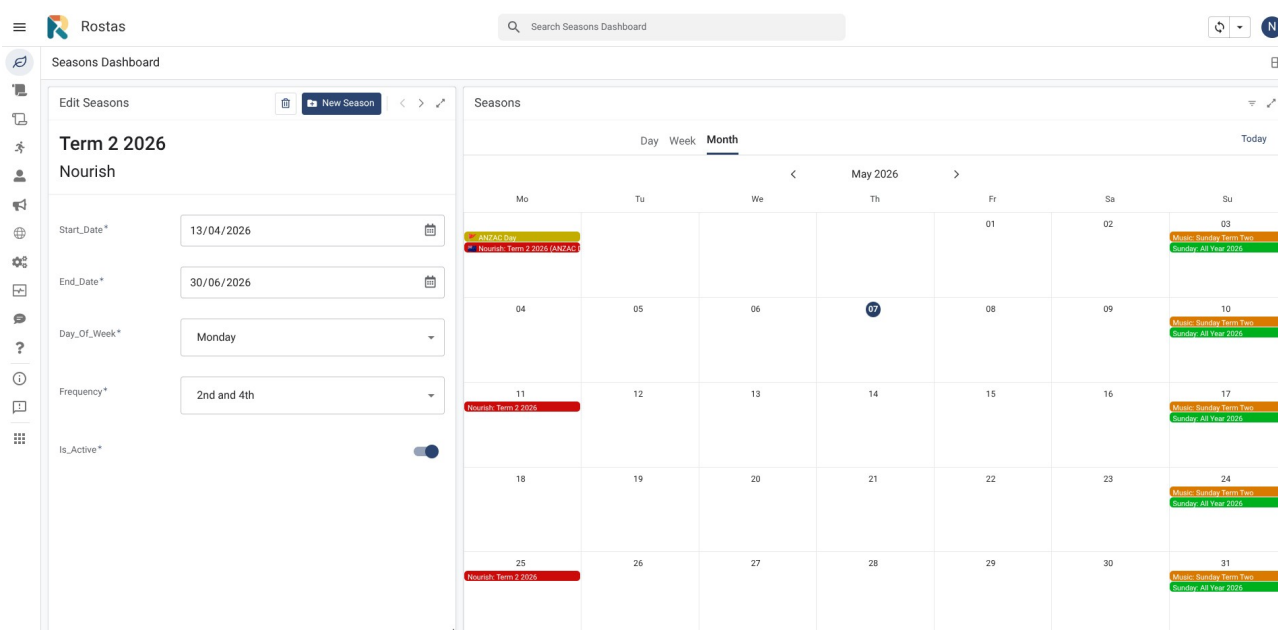
3. Step 0 — Refresh the Seasons Calendar



Run this at the start of each roster build and any time you make changes to season dates. It recalculates all roster dates, overlays NZ public holidays and school holidays, and updates the calendar view.

Step 0 — Refresh calendar

In Rostas → Run Commands, tap **0. Refresh calendar**. Wait for the result message to confirm completion. Check the Seasons Calendar view to confirm dates look correct.



Seasons Dashboard — month calendar view showing all active seasons colour-coded by roster type. Select or create a season in the Edit Seasons panel on the left to view or edit start/end dates, day of week, frequency, and active status.

Always run Step 0 after editing season start/end dates, adding a new season, or at the beginning of a new roster cycle.

Step 2 — Role Preferences

 Volunteers Roles

 Roles List

Role preferences tell the system which roles each volunteer is willing to do. The system needs this information before it can build the roster.

Option A — Volunteers Set Their Own Preferences

Volunteers receive a personalised link and tap through each role, choosing 'Yes I do this', 'Happy to fill in', or 'Not for me'.

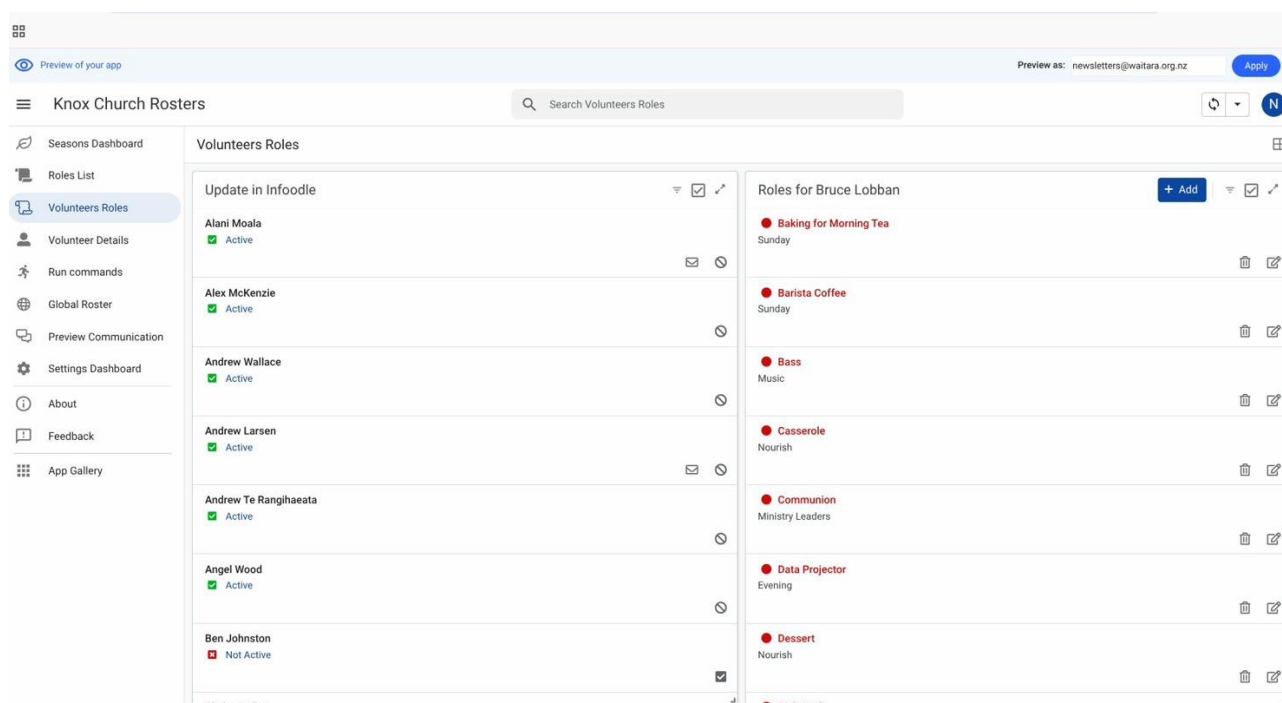
Step 2 — Send role preference emails

In Rostas → Run Commands, tap **2. Send role preference emails**. Volunteers receive an email with a personalised link. Allow a few days for responses before building the roster. Check who has responded in the Volunteers Roles view.

Option B — You Set Preferences for the Volunteer

If a volunteer is not comfortable using the link, or for new volunteers who have not yet set preferences, you can set their roles directly in Rostas.

Open the **Volunteers Roles** view. Select the volunteer on the left, then review and edit their role assignments on the right.



Volunteers Roles view — select a volunteer on the left to see and edit their role assignments on the right.

Volunteer Frequency Settings

Individual Details

Frequency settings control how many times per month a volunteer can be rostered for a given roster type. The roster engine strictly enforces these caps.

To set or update frequency:

1. In Rostas, go to the **Individual Details** view. Select the volunteer from the left panel.
2. Use the arrow buttons (< >) to switch between roster types if the volunteer serves in more than one roster.
3. In the **Max Days Rostered** panel (bottom centre), tap 1, 2, 3, or 4 to set the monthly maximum. The default is 4 for weekly rosters, 2 for fortnightly rosters.
4. Add a note if helpful (e.g. '4th Monday only' or 'family commitments 1st Wednesday').
5. Save. The change takes effect at the next roster build.

Volunteer Details view — volunteer list on the left, Roster Assign List (top centre), Availability Choices (bottom centre), and Edit Frequency panel on the right.

Frequency settings panel — tap a number to set the monthly cap for that roster type. Use the arrows to switch between roster types.

Frequency caps are enforced automatically at roster build time. A volunteer who has already reached their monthly cap will not be assigned to any further dates in that month, even if they are marked Available.

6. Step 3 — Send Availability Emails



Availability emails go to all active volunteers for your roster type. Each volunteer receives a personalised link showing the upcoming dates. They tap each date to mark themselves Available, Unsure, or Can't make it, then tap Save.

Step 3 — Send availability emails

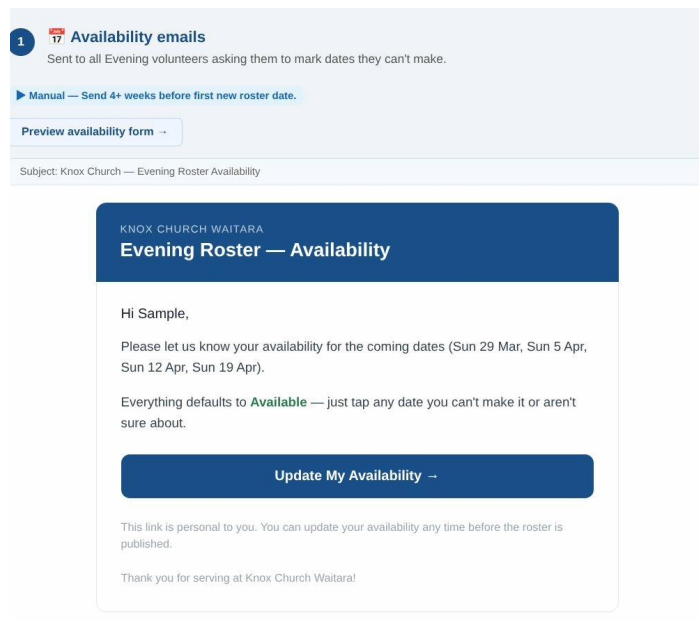
In Rostas → Run Commands, tap **3. Send availability emails**. The result confirms how many emails were sent. Allow 5–7 days for volunteers to respond. Volunteers who do not respond are treated as Unavailable at roster build time.

The screenshot displays the Rostas application interface. On the left, the 'Run commands' menu is visible, with '3. SEND AVAILABILITY EMAILS' selected. The main panel shows the 'Roster commands' list, including '0. REFRESH CALENDAR', '1. SYNC VOLUNTEERS', and '2. SEND ROLE PREFERENCE EMAILS'. The 'Command history' panel on the right shows a list of completed commands, including 'refreshactions' and 'refreshSeasonsC...'. The 'Date Roster' panel on the far right shows a calendar for April 2026, with volunteers assigned to various roles (Music, Nourish, Sound Tech) for specific dates.

Command	Parameters	Status	Requested_By	Request Date
refreshactions		Complete	newsletters@waita...	11/4/2
refreshactions		Complete	newsletters@waita...	10/4/2
refreshactions		Complete	newsletters@waita...	10/4/2
refreshactions		Complete	newsletters@waita...	10/4/2
refreshactions		Complete	newsletters@waita...	10/4/2
refreshSeasonsC...		Complete	newsletters@waita...	10/4/2
refreshactions		Complete	newsletters@waita...	10/4/3

Service Date	Instrument	Volunteer Name	Status	Role
19/4/2026	Guitar Acoustic	Connor Parsons	Filled	Mus
19/4/2026	Guitar Acoustic	Sam Parsons	Pending	Mus
19/4/2026	Sound Tech	Alani Moala	Filled	Mus
19/4/2026	Sound Tech	Lesley Smith - McDon...	Filled	Mus
19/4/2026	Electric	Andrew Wallace	Filled	Mus
19/4/2026	Drums	Caleb Marshall	Filled	Mus
19/4/2026	keys	Lisa Parsons	Filled	Mug

Run Commands — Step 3 (Send availability emails) and Step 4 (Build roster) buttons. The Command history panel on the right shows completed actions.



The availability email volunteers receive — a personalised link takes them straight to the form.

The Three Availability States **Available** — The default starting state for all dates. **Unsure** — Signals caution. The volunteer may be provisionally assigned. **Can't make it** — Immediately removes them from the scheduling pool for that date. Everything starts as Available — volunteers only spend time changing the dates they cannot make.



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Waitara

Music Roster

Availability Form

Hi Guy Pilkinton,

Tap any date to change your availability. Everything starts as Available — only change the ones you can't make.

● Available
 ● Unsure
 ● Not available

APR 19	APR 26	MAY 3	MAY 10	MAY 17	MAY 24
Sunday	Sunday	Sunday	Sunday	Sunday	Sunday
✓	✓	✗	✓	?	✓
Available	Available	Can't make it	Available	Not sure	Available

Save my availability

The availability form — volunteers tap each date card to cycle through Available, Unsure, and Can't make it, then tap Save.

What if someone missed the email?

You can update a volunteer's availability directly in Rostas via the **Individual Details** view. Select the volunteer from the left panel, then use the Availability Requests panel (bottom right) to find the date and update their status.

Step 4 — Build the Roster



The roster engine assigns volunteers to roles based on their availability and role preferences. It works through four priority tiers and within each tier selects the volunteer who has been rostered least recently.

The Four Priority Tiers

Step 4 — Build roster

In Rostas → Run Commands, tap **4. Build roster**. The Music roster can take up to 10 minutes — this is normal. The system builds the next 8 weeks of dates by default (configurable per roster type in Settings — `ROSTER_BUILD_WEEKS_{Type}`). Check the result message: Filled, Pending, and Unfilled counts. Review the roster in the Global Roster view before sending.

Reviewing the Result — The Traffic Light System

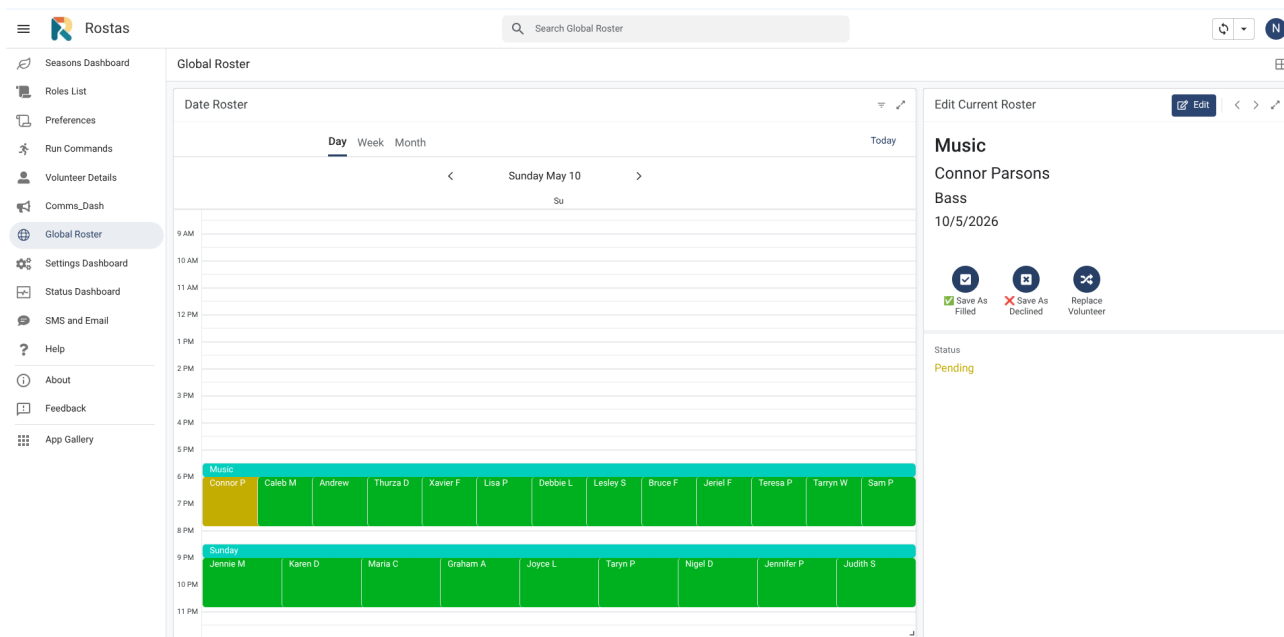
Do not send notifications until you have reviewed the roster. Check for Unfilled slots and any obvious problems first. Once notifications are sent, volunteers receive their assignments immediately.

Editing the Roster Before Sending

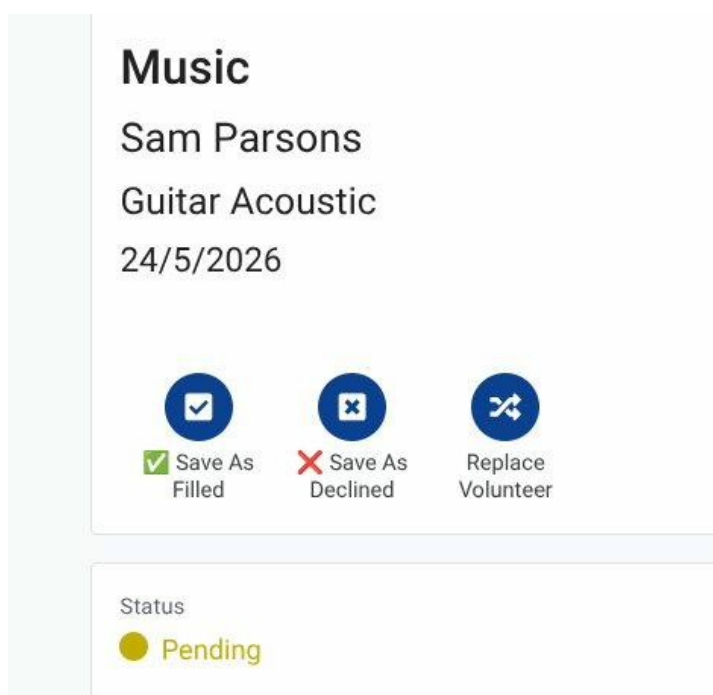
In the Global Roster view, tap or click any assignment to open the edit panel on the right. You will see three options: Take particular notice of any red (unfilled dates - These dates may require you to find a replacement or it may be workable to have less volunteers on duty that week)

You also have the Following Options at this Stage

- **Replace Volunteer** — a drop-down offers a list of possible replacement volunteers.
- **Save as Filled** — manually confirm a Pending (Unsure) assignment.
- **Save as Declined** — this automatically starts the SMS replacement chain to find a substitute.



Global Roster Day view — calendar view with Day, Week, and Month tabs. Tap any assignment to open the edit panel on the right with Save As Filled, Save As Declined, and Replace Volunteer options.



The assignment edit panel — Save As Filled confirms a Pending assignment; Save As Declined starts the SMS replacement chain; Swap Volunteer lets you manually select a replacement.

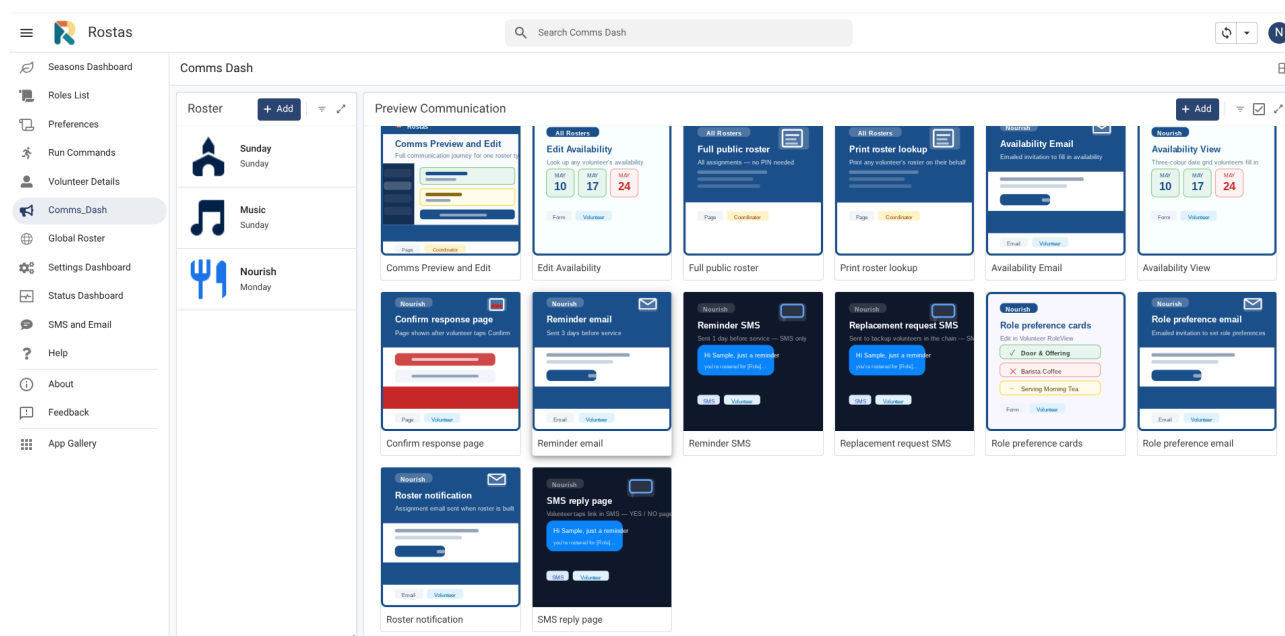
Step 5 — Preview Communications

Communications

Before sending notifications, use the **Comms Dash** view to see exactly what every communication step will look like — notification emails, reminder emails, SMS messages, and the volunteer reply pages.

Step 5 — Preview communications

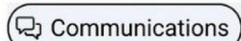
In Rostas → **Comms Dash**, select a roster type from the list on the left. A full grid of communication cards appears on the right — each card represents one step in the volunteer communication journey. Tap any card to open a live preview. Check volunteer names, roles, dates, links, and message wording. Close the preview and proceed to Step 6 when satisfied.



Comms Dash view — select a roster on the left, then browse the full grid of communication previews on the right. Each card opens a live preview of that communication step.

Keep any wording changes generic and appropriate for all roster types, or revert changes afterwards so the next coordinator does not encounter problems.

Step 6 — Send Notifications



Notifications go to every volunteer with a Filled or Pending assignment. Each volunteer receives an email with their role and date, and a link to confirm (for pending) or decline. An SMS is also sent.

Step 6 — Send notifications

In Rostas → Run Commands, tap **6. Send Notifications**. The result confirms how many volunteers were notified. Volunteers receive their email and SMS within a few minutes.

What volunteers receive: Each volunteer gets an email showing their name, role, and dates rostered. The email includes a *Can't make it* link. If they tap it, the SMS replacement chain runs automatically — coordinators do not need to do anything when this happens. There is also a link to a simplified printable roster. For Pending (Unsure) assignments, volunteers are shown *Yes, I can make it* and *Can't make it* buttons so they can confirm or decline a date they were unsure about when the availability email was sent.

Manual Replacement

 Global Roster

 Individual Details

Use manual replacement when a volunteer contacts you directly — for example, they phone to say they cannot make it and suggest someone else, or you need to make a swap yourself without waiting for the SMS chain.

Manual replace

Go to Rostas → Global Roster or Individual Details view. Select the assignment you want to change. Tap **Replace Volunteer**, then select the replacement from the dropdown. Save. The system processes the swap within 1 minute. Check the Status column — it changes from Pending to Done when complete.

The replacement volunteer receives an automatic notification after a manual swap, with the usual links to the "I can't make it" button, roster view, and print roster.

11. The SMS Replacement Chain

When a volunteer taps 'Can't make it' in their notification email, the system automatically begins contacting other available volunteers by SMS one at a time.

What happens automatically:

- The system finds the next suitable available volunteer for that role and date.
- It sends them an SMS with a link to accept or decline.
- If they **accept** → they are added to the roster and the chain stops.
- If they **decline or do not respond** within 2 hours (standard) or 15 minutes (urgent/imminent events) → the next volunteer is contacted.
- If no one accepts → the coordinator receives an email letting you know the slot is still unfilled.

Quiet Hours: SMS messages are not sent between 9:00 PM and 7:00 AM NZ time. If the chain is running overnight, it pauses and resumes in the morning. Quiet hours can be adjusted in Settings — search for 'Quiet'.

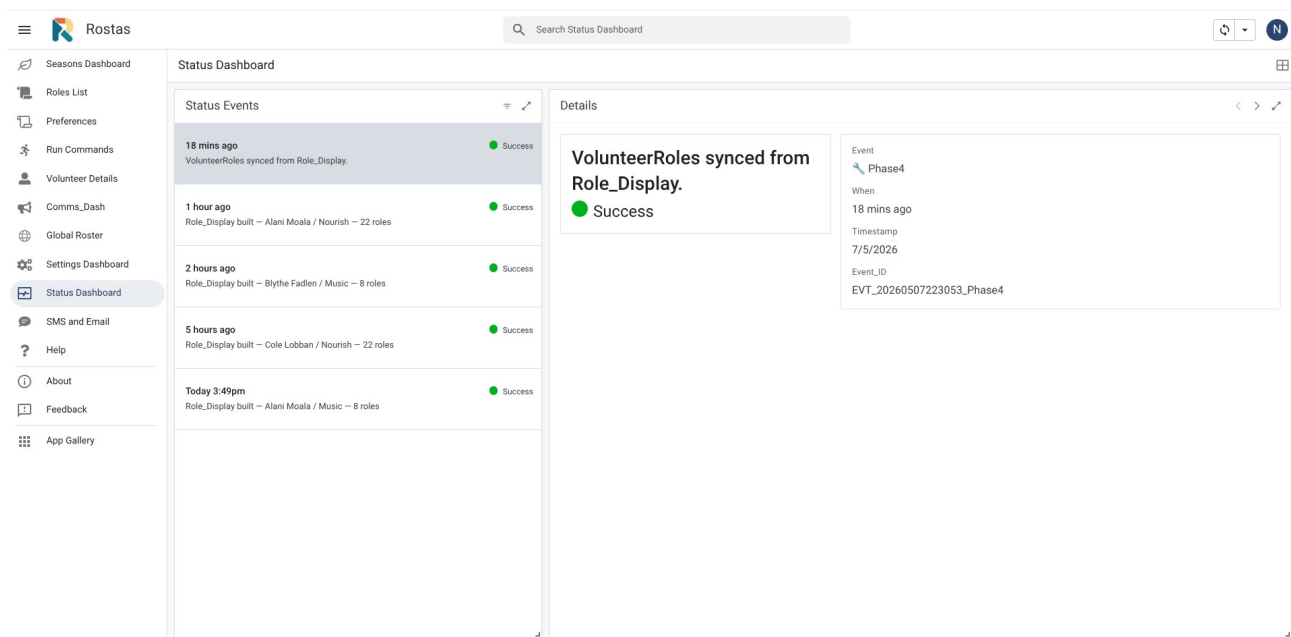
Fairness — Being replaced has one coded consequence: When a volunteer is replaced — whether they tapped Can't make it or were manually swapped by a coordinator — the system remembers. The next time a replacement is needed for a role they can do, they are given gentle priority to be contacted first. This gives them the chance to step up when they're free. They can always decline, no explanation needed. Once they serve in any capacity, this priority is automatically cleared. There's no ongoing obligation — just a quiet nudge to give willing volunteers a chance to contribute again.

12. Checking the Status Dashboard

Status Dashboard

The Status Dashboard shows the status of all notifications sent from Rostas — emails, SMS reminders, and replacement requests. Check it after running any notification step to confirm delivery. If an error appears, use the **Email Tech Support** button to send an error report to Tech Support that automatically contains the error report.

Note: the full Audit Log is accessible to Technical Support only. If something does not look right, contact Tech Support and send the error message.



Status Dashboard — all system events with timestamps and success/error indicators. Tap any row to see full details in the right panel.

Common things to look for:

- **SMS FAILED** — a text message did not deliver. Usually a Twilio issue (or ClickSend if you have switched providers). Note the error and contact Tech Support if it persists.
- **Chain exhausted** — no volunteer accepted the replacement. The slot is still unfilled.
- **Assignment not found** — a Manual Replace request used an incorrect assignment. Check and resubmit.

If you see repeated errors, do not keep retrying. Note what you were doing and the error message, and contact tech support. Retrying a failed action can sometimes create duplicate assignments.

Managing Volunteer SMS and Email Opt-outs

Volunteers can opt out of receiving roster SMS messages and/or emails at any time using a self-service preferences link that appears at the bottom of every Rostas email, on the SMS reply page, and on the availability and role preference form success screens. Coordinators can also view and override any volunteer's opt-out status from the **SMS and Email** view in Rostas.

How volunteers opt out

Every email sent by Rostas includes a "Manage email and SMS preferences" link in the footer. Tapping it opens a simple self-service page where the volunteer can toggle SMS and email on or off independently. Changes take effect immediately — no sync is required.

- Every roster notification email
- Every reminder email (sent before each service)
- Every availability request email
- Every role preference invitation email
- The SMS replacement respond page (YES / NO buttons)
- The availability form success screen
- The role preference form success screen (volunteer mode only)

Coordinator view — SMS and Email

The **SMS and Email** view in Rostas shows all volunteers with their current *SMS opted out* and *Email opted out* status. Select any volunteer from the list on the left to see and edit their opt-out flags in the Details panel on the right. Two **NO / Yes** toggle buttons appear — tap **Yes** to record an opt-out, tap **NO** to reinstate normal sending. Changes save immediately.

SMS and Email view — the volunteer list shows current opt-out status for all volunteers. Select a volunteer to view and edit their SMS and Email toggles in the Details panel on the right.

Opted-out volunteers are counted as **Skipped** in send results — not as Errors. A result showing "Skipped: 2" alongside sent counts is expected when opted-out volunteers are bypassed.

Volunteers who have never received a Rostas communication cannot reach the self-service preferences page themselves — the link requires a personalised volunteer ID in the URL. If a volunteer requests an opt-out before receiving their first email or SMS, use the SMS and Email view to set their status directly.

Step 1 — Volunteer Sync from Infoodle



Infoodle is a membership database. Rostas syncs volunteer data from Infoodle every morning at 2am automatically. You can also run a manual sync at any time Using the (Commands view - Pull latest member data from infoodle).

Run a manual sync when:

- A new volunteer has been added to Infoodle and needs to appear in Rostas immediately.
- A volunteer's contact details (email or mobile) have changed in Infoodle.
- You are about to build a roster and want to make sure you have the latest data.

Step 1 — Sync volunteers from Infoodle

In Rostas → Run Commands, tap **1. Sync volunteers from Infoodle**. The sync runs in two steps and takes about 1-2 minutes. The result confirms how many volunteers were updated. Check the Volunteers view to confirm new or updated records appear.

Important: Volunteer name changes and Group/Roster membership are only editable in Infoodle, not in Rostas. Always update volunteer details in Infoodle first, then run a sync.

Adding a New Volunteer

New volunteers must be added to Infoodle first and assigned to the correct Infoodle group for their roster type. Once in Infoodle, run a manual sync and they will appear in Rostas. You will then need to set their role preferences before they can be included in a roster build.

Settings and Configuration



System settings control how Rostas behaves — coordinator contacts, reminder timing, message wording, and which features are active. All settings are managed through the **Settings Dashboard** view in Rostas. Settings are grouped by category; tap a row to view details and use Edit to change a value.

Settings Dashboard — settings are grouped by category. Tap a row to view details and use Edit to change a value.

Two types of editable fields: Numeric settings use a button selector — tap the value you want. Boolean settings (on/off) use a toggle switch. Text settings use a free-text field. Never edit a setting's *key name* — only the value column.

Coordinator Contact Details

Each roster type has its own coordinator name, email, and mobile number used in outgoing messages, escalation alerts, and the SMS replacement chain. The general COORDINATOR_NAME / EMAIL / PHONE keys are used as fallbacks where no type-specific value is set.

Phone numbers must be in +64 international format with no spaces — e.g. +64211234567. An incorrectly formatted number will cause SMS delivery to fail silently.

Email Notification Templates

These settings control the wording of the roster notification email sent to volunteers at Step 6. Use the **Preview Communications** button to check how changes look before sending to volunteers.

Reminder Settings

These settings control when and how reminder messages are sent to volunteers in the days before a service. Reminder emails and SMS are sent automatically — no manual action is required once these are configured.

SMS Replacement Chain Templates

These settings control the wording of all SMS messages sent during the replacement chain — when a volunteer declines and Rostas works through the backup list to find a replacement.

SMS Provider

Rostas supports two SMS providers: **Twilio** and **ClickSend**. The active provider is controlled by the SMS_PROVIDER key in the Message Wording settings — no code changes are needed to switch. Twilio is currently the active provider.

The screenshot shows the Rostas Settings Dashboard. On the left is a sidebar with navigation links: Seasons Dashboard, Roles List, Preferences, Run Commands, Volunteer Details, Comms-Dash, Global Roster, Settings Dashboard (selected), Status Dashboard, SMS and Email, Help, About, Feedback, and App Gallery. The main area is titled 'Settings Dashboard' and contains three panels. The 'Settings Categories' panel on the left lists: Contacts, Message Wording, Timing & Behaviour, Quick Controls, Tech Support Only, and Add Roster. The 'Message Wording List' panel in the center shows a table of settings:

Setting	Description
SMS_REPLACEMENT_REQUEST	Replacement request SMS. Placeholders: [Name] [...]
SMS_TEMPLATE_CONFIRM	Confirmation SMS sent to the replacement volunte...
SMS_TEMPLATE_RELEASE	SMS sent to the original volunteer when their slot i...
SMS_TEMPLATE_ESCALATE	SMS sent to coordinator when the backup list is e...
SMS_YES_MESSAGE	
SMS_NO_MESSAGE	
SMS_MANUAL_REPLACE	Edit Manual Replace text message
SMS_PROVIDER	'clicksend' Routes through ClickSend (default), 't...
CLICKSEND_USERNAME	User Name
CLICKSEND_API_KEY	API Key
CLICKSEND_FROM	The From Name SMS receivers see
EMAIL_SUBJECT	Subject line of the roster email
EMAIL_INTRO_TEXT	Opening text of the roster email. Use [Name] as a ...
EMAIL_INTRO	For Next (x) Weeks Roster Email
EMAIL_ARRIVAL_NOTE	For Next (x) Weeks Roster Email
EMAIL_SIGNOFF	For Next (x) Weeks Roster Email
ROLE_PREF_ROSTER_TYPES	Roster types that use role preference emails. Com...
REMINDER_INTRO_TEXT	
REMINDER_CANT_MAKE_IT	

The 'Settings Detail View' panel on the right shows details for 'SMS_TEMPLATE_RELEASE'. It includes the category 'Message Wording', the setting name 'SMS_TEMPLATE_RELEASE', and the description 'SMS sent to the original volunteer when their slot is covered'. The 'Edit' section shows the current value: 'Hi [Name], no problem at all — we have found a replacement for [Role] on [Date]. — Teresa.'

Message Wording settings — now includes SMS_PROVIDER and ClickSend configuration keys alongside the SMS templates. Tap any row to edit in the right-hand panel.

Switching providers: To switch to ClickSend, set SMS_PROVIDER = clicksend in the Message Wording settings. To switch back to Twilio, set SMS_PROVIDER = twilio. No other changes are needed — credentials for both providers are stored in Settings.

Timing and Roster Engine

These settings control how far ahead rosters are built, how long volunteers have to respond, and how quickly the SMS replacement chain moves between contacts.

Numeric settings use a button selector in the Settings Dashboard — tap the value you want.

Role and Roster Preferences

Testing and Live Mode Controls

Three settings control whether Rostas contacts real volunteers or redirects everything to the coordinator for testing. These must be correctly set before go-live and should only be changed deliberately.

- SMS_TEST_MODE → **OFF** (currently ON — change before going live)
- EMAIL_TEST_MODE → **OFF** (currently ON — change before going live)
- SMS_ENABLED → **ON** (currently OFF — enable when ready to send real SMS)

If you are unsure whether the system is in live or test mode, check the Status Dashboard — it shows a *Test Mode active* banner when either test mode is on. Always send a Preview and verify a real volunteer email arrives before treating the system as live.

Settings Managed by Tech Support

The following settings are visible in the Settings Dashboard but should not be edited by coordinators. Each is explained below so you understand what it does and why it is restricted.

This is the URL of the volunteer-facing web app — the availability form, the confirm/decline pages, and the personal roster view. It is generated by Google Apps Script and does not change unless the script is redeployed from scratch.

Redeployment is a rare technical operation (typically done when recovering from a corrupted deployment or migrating to a new Google account). When it happens, every link previously sent to volunteers stops working until this setting is updated and the Sync Preview URLs tool is run.

What to do: Tech support will handle the update. You do not need to action anything — you will know it has happened because volunteer links will start returning errors. See Part D for the technical procedure.

A comma-separated list of Infoodle group numbers that Rostas pulls from during the volunteer sync. Each number corresponds to one volunteer group in Infoodle. The group number is the `id=` value in the Infoodle URL when you open that group.

Why it's restricted: Adding an incorrect group ID causes the sync to attempt to pull from a non-existent or unrelated group. Removing a group ID means those volunteers disappear from Rostas on the next sync. Coordinators may be asked by tech support to look up a group ID — open the group in Infoodle and copy the number after `id=` in the browser URL bar.

This setting maps each Infoodle group ID to a roster type, using the format `499:Sunday, 464:Music, 502:Nourish`. It tells the sync engine which volunteers belong to which roster. A volunteer in multiple Infoodle groups will appear in multiple roster types.

Why it's restricted: The format is precise — a stray comma, a missing colon, a space in the wrong place, or a roster type name that doesn't exactly match the `ROSTER_TYPES` list will silently break the volunteer sync. Even experienced users have introduced bugs here. Always ask tech support to update this setting when adding or removing roster types.

This setting holds the comma-separated list of active roster types — e.g. Sunday, Music, Nourish. It looks simple but editing it directly is not the right way to add a roster type.

Why it's restricted: Adding a name to this list alone does nothing useful — a new roster type also requires coordinator contact keys, a build-weeks setting, an Infoodle group mapping, roles in the Master Roles list, and a season. If you add the name here without those, the build engine will fail when it tries to use the incomplete configuration. Use the **Add Roster Type** button in Run Commands instead — it scaffolds everything in one step. See Adding a New Roster Type.

Infoodle credentials (Site Code, Client ID, Client Secret) and **Twilio credentials** (Account SID, Auth Token, From Number) are also visible in the Settings Dashboard. These are private API keys — treat them like passwords. Never share them and never edit them without guidance from tech support.

When to Contact Tech Support

Most day-to-day operations are fully self-contained in Rostas. The situations below require more technical involvement:

- The volunteer web app URL has changed and needs updating (after a system redeployment).
- Repeated errors appear in the Status Dashboard that do not resolve on their own.
- SMS messages stop delivering to volunteers.
- The system triggers need to be reinstalled (e.g. after a technical issue).
- Any change to Infoodle connection settings or API credentials.
- Anything that requires opening the Apps Script editor.

Adding a New Roster Type

 Settings Dashboard

New roster types (e.g. a Community Meal) can be added by an Overall Coordinator directly through Rostas without needing to contact Tech Support. The process takes about 5 minutes and the system scaffolds all required Config keys automatically.

Before you start: Confirm the Infoodle group for the new roster type exists and you have its numeric Group ID. If the group has not been created yet, create it in Infoodle first, add the relevant volunteers to it, then come back here.

Step 1 — Add the Roster Type in Rostas

Step 1 — Add the Roster Type in Rostas

Go to Rostas → **Settings Dashboard** → **Add New Roster**. Fill in the form:

- **Roster Name** — the internal name (e.g. *Community_Meal*). Title case, no spaces in the middle.
- **Coordinator Name, Email, Phone** — the coordinator for this roster type.
- **Calendar Time Slot** — display order on the Seasons Calendar. Use 3 or 4 for a new type if the Roster is the 3 and 4 roster on that day. This gives different rosters visual separation in the Calendar.
- **Infoodle Group ID** — the numeric group ID. If unsure, run Knox Roster → Developer tools → List all groups.

Save the row. This automatically queues an `addRosterType` command in the Commands tab.

Add Role form — fill in all required fields when adding a new roster type or role.

Step 2 — Wait 1 Minute

Step 2 — Wait 1 Minute

The command poller picks up the addRosterType command and scaffolds all Config keys:

- COORDINATOR_{TYPE}, COORDINATOR_{TYPE}_EMAIL, COORDINATOR_{TYPE}_PHONE
- SEASONS_SLOT_{type}, ROSTER_BUILD_WEEKS_{type}
- Adds the type to ROSTER_TYPES and INFOODLE_GROUP_MAP

Check the Command history panel — the result shows the number of keys added.

Step 3 — Add Roles in Edit Roles

Step 3 — Add Roles

Go to Rostas → **Edit Roles**. Add each role for the new roster type — set **Roster_Type** to the new name exactly. Set **Is_Active = Active**, and set Min/Max People as needed.

Step 4 — Add a Season

Step 4 — Add a Season

Go to Rostas → **Seasons Dashboard**. Add a new season — set start and end dates, frequency (Weekly or Fortnightly), day of week, and **Is_Active = TRUE**.

Step 5 — Refresh Calendar and Buttons

Step 5 — Refresh Calendar and Buttons

In Rostas → **Run Commands**:

- Run **0. Refresh calendar** — rebuilds the Seasons Calendar to include the new roster type's dates.
- Run **7. Maintenance → Refresh command buttons** — new Build, Send, and Preview buttons appear for the new type.

Step 6 — Import Historical Data (if applicable)

Step 6 — Import Historical Data

If you have an existing spreadsheet with past assignments for this roster type, import it now. This gives the fairness engine accurate history from day one so it won't re-roster the same people the week after they were already rostered. See Appendix A1 — Import Existing Roster Data for full instructions. If there is no existing history, skip this step.

Step 7 — Set Preferences and Run

Step 7 — Set Preferences and Run

Set Ministry_Pref for volunteers (via Individual Details or after Volunteer Sync once the Infoodle group is populated). Send role preference emails if the roster type uses specialist roles. Then follow Steps 3, 4, 5, and 6 of the Roster Cycle to collect availability, build, preview, and send.

Refresh command buttons: Run 7. Maintenance → Refresh command buttons any time the Run Commands panel looks wrong — missing buttons, wrong labels, or buttons for inactive types still appearing. This is safe to run at any time.

Removing a Roster Type

If a roster type is no longer needed, it can be removed. This deactivates its roles and seasons, removes its Config keys, and rebuilds the Run Commands buttons. Historical assignment records are not deleted — they remain in RosterAssignments for reference.

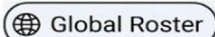
This cannot be undone automatically. Make sure you genuinely want to remove the roster type. If you might need it again, set its season `Is_Active = FALSE` instead — that stops it appearing in builds without removing any data.

Rostas Run Commands

Delete via Run Commands

Go to Rostas → **Run Commands** → **Step 7 Maintenance**. A *Delete Roster type* button appears for each active roster type. Tap the button for the Roster_type you want to remove. The system processes the deletion within 1 minute. Check Command history for the result — it confirms Config keys, roles, seasons, and frequency rows removed.

Coordinator-Triggered Decline and Replace



The standard Manual Replacement (Section 10) lets you pick a specific replacement volunteer directly. Decline and Replace is different — it marks a volunteer as declined and hands control to the automated SMS chain, which contacts available volunteers one by one until someone accepts.

Use this when a volunteer contacts you to say they cannot make it, but you do not have a specific replacement in mind and prefer the system to find one.

Comparison: Manual Replacement vs Decline and Replace

Quiet hours apply: If you trigger Decline and Replace between 9pm and 7am NZ time, the SMS chain queues until 7am. For urgent same-day slots, contact potential replacements directly in parallel.

D1. Import Existing Roster Data

The Import Existing Roster function loads a manually-made roster into Rostas. It is used in two situations: importing Your text here. Your text here. Your text here. a brand-new roster type from a spreadsheet the coordinator has already been running, or seeding historical data before go-live so the fairness engine has accurate assignment history from day one.

Access required: This function is only accessible from the Apps Script editor — it is not available in the Rostas AppSheet app. It requires access to the Google account that owns the spreadsheet, and (for AI cleaning) an OpenAI API key stored in Script Properties.

When to Use Import

Use Import when:

- Setting up Rostas for the first time and you have an existing roster spreadsheet to carry over. This can help with importing some data (e.g. Role_Type selections and Frequency selections) providing a smooth transition between the old manually produced roster system and the new Rostas system
- Adding a new roster type and you want to give the system historical assignment data so it applies fairness rotation from the start.
- A previous roster season was managed manually and you want it visible in the Roster Assignments history.

Do not use Import to:

- Fix or edit existing assignments — use Manual Replacement or edit directly in Rostas instead.
- Re-import data that is already in RosterAssignments — the script skips rows with duplicate Assignment IDs but will add rows if you paste fresh data with new IDs.

Prerequisites

Step-by-Step: Pivot Format (Recommended)

All steps are run from the **Knox Roster** menu in the spreadsheet menu bar. Pivot format is recommended when your existing roster is a grid (dates across the top, roles down the side).

Step A — Open the Apps Script Editor

In the Rostas spreadsheet: **Extensions → Apps Script**. The Knox Roster project opens. You do not need to edit any code. All actions are run from the Knox Roster menu at the top.

Step B — Create the ImportPivot Tab

If the Import Pivot Tab has not yet been created In the spreadsheet menu: Find the **Phase9_ImportRoster** Script (left side) click on **Knox Roster → Import Existing Roster → Setup — Create Pivot tab**. This creates an ImportPivot tab with sample data showing the expected format. Delete the sample rows (rows 2–4) before pasting your data.

Step C — Paste Your Existing Roster

Open your source spreadsheet. Copy the roster grid — including the header row with dates and the role column. Paste it into cell A1 of the ImportPivot tab. Expected layout:

- Row 1: Roles | 13/04/2026 | 27/04/2026 | ...
- Row 2+: Soup | Jane Smith | Bronnie H | ...

Volunteer names can include informal names, initials, and pairs (e.g. "Bruce & Cole"). The AI cleaning step resolves these.

Step D — Run AI Cleaning (Recommended)

In the **Phase9_ImportRoster** Script menu: → **Import Existing Roster → 1. Clean roster with AI**. The AI reads your pasted roster and compares every volunteer name and role name against the Volunteers tab and Master_Roles tab. It resolves: nicknames and informal names (e.g. "Bronnie" → "Bronwyn Harrison"), last-name-only references, minor role name variations, and pairs listed in one cell. The cleaned version is written back into ImportPivot. New nickname mappings are saved to the Nickname_Map tab. Review the cleaned ImportPivot tab before importing.

If AI cleaning fails: Check that the `OPENAI_API_KEY` is present in Apps Script → Project Settings → Script Properties. You can proceed without AI cleaning — names that do not match will be flagged in the import result as "Unmatched names". Fix them in ImportPivot and re-run.

Step E — Run the Import

In the spreadsheet menu: **Knox Roster → Import Existing Roster → 2. Import (Pivot format)**. A dialog asks you to confirm the Roster Type. Select the correct type and confirm. The import shows a results dialog:

-  **Written** — assignments successfully added to RosterAssignments.
-  **Skipped** — rows already present in RosterAssignments — safe to ignore.
-  **Unmatched names** — volunteer names that could not be resolved. Cells highlighted red in ImportPivot.
-  **Unknown roles** — role names not found in Master_Roles. Add and re-

run.

Correct any highlighted cells and re-run until zero unmatched names and zero unknown roles.

Step F — Seed Volunteer Roles from Import

In the **Phase9_ImportRoster** Script menu → **Import Existing Roster** → **4. Seed volunteer roles from import**. Reads the imported RosterAssignments and creates VolunteerRoles entries for each volunteer-role pairing found. Does not overwrite any existing VolunteerRoles entries.

Step G — Seed Volunteer Frequency from Import

In the **Phase9_ImportRoster** menu: → **Import Existing Roster** → **5. Seed volunteer frequency from import**. Counts how many times each volunteer appears in the imported data and creates VolunteerFrequency entries. Gives the fairness rotation engine a realistic starting point so the first build does not roster the same people who just served.

After steps F and G: The system is ready to build its first roster. Check the Individual Details view for a few volunteers to confirm their frequency counts look right before running the first build.

Alternative: Flat Format

If your source data is a simple list rather than a grid, use the flat format instead.

Setup — Create the ImportRoster Tab

Knox Roster → Import Existing Roster → Setup — Create Flat tab. Delete the example row and paste or type your data with these columns:

Then run: **Knox Roster** → **Import Existing Roster** → **3. Import (Flat format)**. AI cleaning is not available for flat format. Ensure names and roles are an exact match before importing. Follow Steps F and G above to seed roles and frequency after the import.

After the Import

Do not re-import: Running the import a second time with the same data is safe (existing rows are skipped) but running it with a modified copy will create duplicate assignments with new Assignment IDs. If you need to correct imported

data, delete the affected rows from RosterAssignments and re-run with corrected source data.

Managing the Nickname Map

Each time AI cleaning resolves a new nickname (e.g. "Bronnie" → "Bronwyn Harrison") it saves the mapping to the Nickname_Map tab. This means the same resolution is used automatically in future imports without needing to call the AI again.

To view or edit the nickname map: **Knox Roster → Import Existing Roster → Setup — Manage nickname map**. The Nickname_Map tab opens. Column A is the informal name (lowercase), Column B is the resolved full name. You can add entries manually.

Troubleshooting — Import

D2. After a Webapp Redeployment — Sync Preview URLs

Every time the Apps Script web app is redeployed, Google assigns a new WEBAPP_URL. The Rosters tab stores a Preview_URL column that must be updated whenever this changes.

Symptoms of a stale URL: The Communications view in Rostas shows broken preview links, or volunteers receive broken links in notification emails. Check WEBAPP_URL in Config first — if it has not been updated since the redeployment, update it before running the sync.

Step 1 — Update WEBAPP_URL in Config

In the Apps Script editor: **Deploy → Manage deployments**. Copy the new web app URL. In Rostas → Update Settings, find WEBAPP_URL and paste the new URL. Save.

Step 2 — Sync Preview URLs

In the spreadsheet menu: **Knox Roster → Developer tools → Sync Roster Preview URLs**. Reads WEBAPP_URL and writes the correct ?view=preview&roster=X URL for every active roster in the Rosters tab. Inactive rosters have their Preview_URL cleared automatically.

Step 3 — Confirm

Open WEBAPP_URL?view=preview in a browser. The roster type selector should load. If it shows a permissions error, check the deployment is set to **Anyone** access.

Also runs automatically: syncRosterPreviewUrls() triggers automatically whenever a roster's Is_Active status is toggled in the Rosters tab, so manual running is only needed after a URL change.

D3. Audit Log Pruning

The Audit_Log tab records every system event. Over time this tab grows large. The pruning function trims it to a manageable size without deleting recent entries.

One-Time Setup

Install the Pruning Trigger

In the **Phase9_ImportRoster → Setup — Audit Log Pruning**. Installs a weekly time-based trigger that automatically prunes the Audit_Log. Run this **once at go-live**. Do not run again — duplicate triggers cause double-pruning.

Manual Prune

Prune Now

In the **Dashboard Script → Prune Audit Log Now**. Immediately trims the Audit_Log to the most recent entries. Safe to run at any time. Useful if the tab has grown very large before the trigger was installed.

What gets kept: All ERROR-level entries are always retained. INFO entries older than the configured retention window (default 90 days) are removed. The window can be adjusted in Config — search for AUDIT_LOG.

D4. Clean VolunteerRoles Tab

The VolunteerRoles tab can accumulate blank rows or duplicates over time — particularly after bulk imports or if volunteers submit the role preference form more than once. The cleanup function removes these safely.

Run Cleanup

In the spreadsheet menu: **Knox Roster → (run from menu)** — the function is `cleanVolunteerRoles` in `Maintainance.gs`. If it is not in the menu, open the Apps Script editor, select `cleanVolunteerRoles` from the function dropdown, and click Run. What it removes:

- Rows with a blank `Volunteer_ID` or `Role_ID`.
- Rows where `Role_Type` is not `Primary` or `Fillable`.
- Duplicate `Volunteer_ID` + `Role_ID` combinations.

Safe to re-run: The function only removes invalid or duplicate rows — it never deletes a valid, unique role assignment. A toast notification shows the count of rows kept and removed.

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